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The Tiv of central Nigeria

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HISTORY AND TRADITIONS OF ORIGIN • TRADITIONS OF ORIGIN

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TRADITIONS OF ORIGIN

Tiv in almost all parts of Tivland say today that they came into their present country from the south-east. While they were "coming down" (*sen*, that is, going north-west) they met the Fulani, with whom they lived for a time and from whom they parted peacefully. As evidence they cite the present "joking relationship" (*sengen*) between Tiv and Fulani. After leaving the Fulani, Tiv say, their forefathers had various adventures with the "Bush Tribes" before they finally emerged into the plains where they live today.

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Tiv postulate that long ago, when they were few in number, all Tiv lived in a single large community on top of a hill which they locate to the south-east. Just which hill this may have been is, however, a matter of dispute. Most agree that it was not Swem Hill (on most maps, Ngol Kedju in the Cameroons), but that they passed by Swem on the way down (and Swem holds a unique position in Tiv legend and religion). Akiga, and he gives a widely held version, says the hill was Ibenda, a hill with two summits in what is today Turan. There are several hills in Ikurav Ya (including Bar), which are said to be this original home in Tivland, while other equally knowledgeable elders in the southern areas claim that it was Iwokungun in what is today Takum District, Wukari Division. A few people in Kunav assert that this original settlement was on Ngokuv, a hill in Shangev Ya, but the majority say that the settlement on Ng[unknown]kuv was at a much later date and involved only one large segment of the Tiv, Jechira. People to the north and west, in Masev

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and Iharev, insist that the original hill was Selagi, in what is today Shangev Mbashintiev; the relative position is about the same as that of the southerners to the hills they champion.

The causes given for the break-up of this hill-top community are of two general sorts; many versions of both types can be collected. Some say that the Ugenyi, today identified as Chamba both by Tiv and by the Jukunized Chamba enclaves in Takum, attacked the Tiv settlement; the following flight and dispersal accounts for the present distribution of lineage areas. A somewhat more commonly held view is that the growth of the community led to bitter internal strife and some lineages had moved to other hilltops of their own before the Ugenyi invasion; this explains to Tiv why such large lineages as Iharev, Masev and parts of Jechira have no history of conflict with the Ugenyi.

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That the Ugenyi invasion took place is almost a certainty. It occurs in the legends of many Udam peoples. Long earthwork fortifications just west of the Mkomon River in Takum District are given Ugenyi origin by both Tiv and Chamba. The statement by the Chamba in this area that their forefathers never crossed the Amiri-tamen River lends credence to the story that Tiv were widely distributed at the time of the invasion; by far the greater portion of the Tiv west of the river today do not claim any first-hand conflict between their ancestors and the Ugenyi in any context except the dispersal of the hill-top community, whereas those to the east trace certain culture traits to Ugenyi influence.

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Writers tend to place the Ugenyi invasion in the early 19th century. The only Tiv evidence which supports this date is that one of Koelle's Tiv informants in Sierra Leone, about 1850, claimed to have been captured and sold as a slave by the Ugenyi. Even if Tiv could decide which of their ancestors were alive at this time—by and large they will not try; those who try do not agree—Tiv genealogies would be useless for dating purposes, since they "collapse" at about the fourth to sixth generation from living elders: that is, the early portions of the genealogy, important in the relations between political groups, are more or less stable; the 13 recent portions, used in personal kinship relations, are more or less accurate; between is a limbo into which it is seldom necessary for Tiv to inquire.

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